

Skincare Red Flags

What to check before you buy at Nykaa, a pharmacy or just anywhere.

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01 Ingredient List Red Flags

Fragrance / Parfum (undisclosed)

HIGH CONCERN

A catch-all term that can hide 200+ undisclosed chemicals, which means high allergy and irritation risk, especially for sensitive skin. Look for: 'Fragrance-free' or brands that list specific essential oils at the very end.

Formaldehyde releasers

HIGH CONCERN

Look for: DMDM Hydantoin, Quaternium-15, Imidazolidinyl Urea, Diazolidinyl Urea. These slowly release formaldehyde - a known carcinogen - as a preservative. Common in conditioners and styling products.

Oxybenzone in chemical sunscreens

WATCH OUT

Can interfere with hormones (Endocrine-disrupting potential) if absorbed into bloodstream at measurable levels. EU restricts concentration limits on this. Better alternatives: Tinosorb S, Uvinul A Plus.

PEG compounds on broken or damaged skin

WATCH OUT

Generally safe on intact skin, but act as penetration enhancers - carrying other ingredients deeper than intended when the skin barrier is compromised.

Alcohol Denat. high up the Ingredient List (INCI)

WATCH OUT

If present in the top 5 ingredients, it trips the skin barrier with repeated use. It's fine lower in the list but not as a lead ingredient. "Fatty Alcohols" (like Cetyl or Stearyl alcohol) are actually good and hydrating.



"The first five ingredients usually make up about 80% of the product. If your 'Star Ingredient' (like Vitamin C or Retinol) isn't in the top half, you're mostly paying for water and fillers".

02

Beauty Buzzwords Reality

"Toxin-free" or "Chemical-free"

HIGH CONCERN

Everything is a chemical - including water. No regulatory body in India defines or enforces this term. It signals lazy formulation communication, not superior safety.

"Dermatologist tested"

WATCH OUT

Means a dermatologist interacted with it - not that it was approved, recommended, or clinically validated. One doctor, 48-hour patch test, 10 people qualifies. Ask: tested for what? By how many? Over how long?

"Clinically proven" without a citation

WATCH OUT

Must name the study, sample size, and measured outcome. Perception studies - "88% of 50 women said skin felt smoother" - are not clinical proof. Real studies cite journals or CRO names (e.g. Spincontrol, DermScan).

"Natural" without a certification

WATCH OUT

No regulatory definition in India. ECOCERT or COSMOS certification is the actual standard. Without it, 1% aloe vera in a synthetic base legally qualifies as 'natural.'

"Hypoallergenic"

WATCH OUT

No standardised test or legal definition exists - in India or globally. Entirely brand-defined. Meaningless without allergen disclosure and patch test data to back it.

"Paraben-free" as the hero claim

MYTH

Parabens are among the best-studied preservatives with a strong safety record at approved concentrations. 'Paraben-free' is not automatically safer - the alternative preservative matters far more.



"Natural" doesn't always mean safer, but it often means a shorter shelf life. Remember to check the PAO (Period After Opening) symbol (the little open jar icon). 

03 Formulation Red Flags

Active ingredient listed last or near-last

HIGH CONCERN

The Ingredient List (INCI) order is by descending concentration. If Niacinamide, Vitamin C, or Retinol appears after Phenoxyethanol (the preservative marker), concentration is likely under 0.1% - too low to do anything.

'QS' or 'q.s.' on the ingredient list

HIGH CONCERN

Means 'quantity sufficient' - a placeholder hiding real concentrations. Full Ingredient List (INCI) transparency requires every ingredient listed in actual descending weight order, no exceptions.

Vitamin C in a clear bottle or open jar

WATCH OUT

Ascorbic Acid oxidises rapidly on exposure to light and air. Clear glass or open-jar packaging works against the formula. Look for: Dark amber glass or airless pumps to keep your serum powerful.

No batch number or manufacturing date

WATCH OUT

Mandatory under Indian Cosmetics Rules 2020. Missing batch info = no traceability. You cannot verify freshness, report an adverse reaction, or check a recall.

Sunscreen with SPF but no PA rating

WATCH OUT

SPF covers UVB only. UVA - the ray driving ageing and pigmentation - requires PA+++ or above. Indian skin is especially prone to UVA-driven pigmentation. No PA = incomplete protection.

The 30-Second Shelf Check

- ✓ Full Ingredient List (INCI) list printed on the pack?
- ✓ Active ingredient in the top half Ingredients (INCI)?
- ✓ Batch number and MFG date visible?
- ✓ Brand claims independently verifiable?
- ✓ Fragrance disclosed with allergens listed?
- ✓ Packaging protects formula (opaque/airless)?
- ✓ Sunscreen shows PA rating alongside SPF?

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